

Her assistant there was the learned Volmar, a monk and scribe who, in accordance with standard monastic practice, became her secretary and helped to document her visions. He was also her spiritual guide, confessor, and companion. His death in 1173, six years before her own, would have been a great personal and professional loss for her.

“ **[Music is] the sacred sound** through
which **all creation resounds.** ”

HILDEGARD OF BINGEN

In 1141 Hildegard recorded a vision of a “... mass of fiery light of the greatest brightness pouring down from the heavens. It enveloped my brain and my heart was kindled with a flame that ... warmed me as the sun warms the earth.” This powerful experience, which she claimed to be divine intervention, prompted her to make public her visions—in part, via her theological texts. The most acclaimed of these are: *Scivias* (*Know the Way*, 1141–1151), thought to have been illustrated by Hildegard herself, which discusses creation, redemption, and salvation; the *Book of Life’s Merits* (1158–1163), an exchange between virtue and vice; and her last great visionary text, *Book of Divine Works* (1163–1174), which outlines the author’s theories on cosmology.